



A KODAK MOMENT: The 22 students who made it to the final list of ET Young Leaders B-School Edition 2015 in their moment of glory share the stage with 10 leading CEOs of India Inc

TALENT LOVES COMPANIES WITH STARTUP DNA

Minutes after a panel of 10 CEOs interviewed 46 aspirants to pick the final list of The Economic Times Young Leaders B-School Edition 2015, they came together for a discussion on how companies can engage better with

Students are able to use their minds more creatively and create value as well.

VIVEK GAMBHIR

Managing Director, Godrej Consumer Products

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PRANAB BARUA

Business Director, Apparel and Retail Business, Aditya Birla Group

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SANJAY RISHI

President, American Express, South Asia

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Deputy Managing Director, Hindalco Industries

Corporate structures need to change as we are far too hierarchical and there are too many layers between the front line and the top. Our HR policies have to start to adapt to a younger generation that will demand a different way of working

REKHA M MENON

Chairman, Accenture India

I would actually argue with you when you say that many big corporations have women leaders. It has to be all across, and done fairly radically.

GURUMURTHI Ajay, what were your key takeaways?

AJAY SRINIVASAN I picked up two major things — a much greater balance between work and other interests, and a lot of people with some really amazing interests outside of work. The second thing was a huge interest in the social sector — I never saw that last year but it was amazing to see the number of people who've aligned themselves to causes and spent time on these causes that they're passionate about. I think both are very wonderful things to see in the youth of today.

REKHA MENON There was such diversity in the background, from their socio-economic background, from the kind of experiences they've had, also from what they've done before starting B-school. I thought to myself, 'My gosh! Even before they've started their MBA they've accomplished so much!'

Diverse Approach
B-schools have a more important job to also ensure that they can create more diversity in classrooms

GURUMURTHI Amit, what was your experience this morning?

AMIT AGARWAL It took me a few moments to get my bearings that I was in the middle of such amazing talent. I'm not an MBA, so it was amazing to know that people can accomplish so much at such a young age. The gender and social diversity were amazing, and the passion and talent that candidates demonstrated were incredible. At that stage, having clarity of purpose matters a lot more.

GURUMURTHI Pranab, could you come in on the point that Amit made about clarity of thought. Is there a stand-out quality that you could see in the candidates here today?

PRANAB BARUA It was good I was sitting on the right side of the table, because if I was sitting on the wrong side of the table, I was sure that I wouldn't get a job. That's the only thing that I was sure of.

Business schools will have to take a look at how they recruit people; what kind of admission tests are there; are those tests much more biased towards male skill sets? I think B-schools have a more important job to also actually ensure that they can create more diversity in their classrooms, and the faculty also has to be more diverse.

MENON We have to do something quickly. In the new Companies Act, it's almost forcing companies to appoint women directors. That's one step. And the other is B-schools, changing their intake. The candidates that we interviewed today, their number was largely biased towards engineering campuses; largely biased towards STEM (science, technology, engineering & mathematics), which is okay, but is that what we really need in business itself? We need a fair number of liberal arts degrees.

GURUMURTHI For a company like Hindalco, it's tough to hire someone from a liberal arts background. The bias towards engineering is obvious. So, how can manufacturing look at a more diverse set of people?

SATISH PAI To say in order to create gender diversity you need to hire from liberal arts is wrong. When we hire trainees now, 30-35% are engineering graduates who are women, so I personally don't think the problem is at the input level. In fact, women have a good representation at the input level. If anywhere there's a problem, it's when you get in at the ecosystem and support systems of the company. The problem is how you propagate it at the middle management level. The middle management has practical issues. In a woman's life, she will have children and then come back onto the treadmill without missing a beat. Even in a metal company, it's not a problem to get women in. But if you hire women and just keep them inside the office in HR roles, you're not doing anything much for them.

GURUMURTHI How can companies support on-campus entrepreneurship?

AGARWAL The things we do is we have a very comprehensive programme — educate, engage and empower. The key focus is how you give them a real-life experience while getting an academic learning. Based on the first part, an internship programme has to be coupled with a strong mentorship programme with a senior leader in the company.

Students are in campuses, they still work on old ways. What's happening is that people are able to use their minds a lot more creatively because of the startup phenomenon.

GURUMURTHI How can Corporate India engage better with students when their aspirations are with startups?

BHATTACHARYA We have this programme called Bizlabs where we engage with the ecosystem of startups and we find ways to scale up and how it's like to work in a sophisticated environment. We saw Stanford University's startup programme called StartX and that's something which encourages students who have been to Stanford and want to come back and use the platform to get incubated and accelerate. They use corporates to engage with and I think there's a possibility waiting to be exploited but B-schools have to start accelerator programmes and corporates will jump at them. We've seen a huge excitement from all our colleagues in the opportunity provided and engage with startups. The time is right. Many students from business schools want to do something with startups and the opportunity is right for conglomerates to step in.

GURUMURTHI Sanjay, what's your view on this visible shift in ambitions? The brightest may not be available for corporates.

RISHI The idea is how do you replicate the environment, all the excitement and risk-taking capacity of a startup? Yet you give them a safety-net of a large corporation and that would be an incredibly powerful value proposition. We won't put you in a rut or a groove. After three years we'll put you in a place to find solutions of a problem that we don't have answers to.

In fact we are discouraging the solution to the problem because the incumbency of the solution is so strong and the traditional view is so strong that people aren't looking for it. So, companies today are rife with problems whether you're in e-commerce or any other business. I think you can achieve very good harmony and we're trying to do that.

MENON It's a very interesting problem and an opportunity. Accenture is now taking minority equity stake in startups which we've never done before. Clearly, that provides the customer with a good harmony and we're trying to do that.

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A young leader takes her citation from Rekha M Menon



Bonding over a selfie



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Old Vs New System

There are youngsters waiting for instructions, but the market outside is telling you to go find and question

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GURUMURTHI Sanjay, what's your view on this visible shift in ambitions? The brightest may not be available for corporates.

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MENON It's a very interesting problem and an opportunity. Accenture is now taking minority equity stake in startups which we've never done before. Clearly, that provides the opportunity for ideas to percolate and that's the only way by which you will encourage diversity of ideas which the old system may not be able to figure out and at the same time provide a base and then we decide on whether or not to fund it.

GURUMURTHI The way jobs were ten or so years ago, will they cease to exist?

BHATTACHARYA Jobs as we see them will cease to exist. We might as well stop looking for instructions. You have to start thinking, ideating, and converting them into action and see where opportunities arise for entrepreneurship and intrapreneur-

to start to adapt to a younger generation that will demand a different way of working than the 'sir' and 'madam' ways of working seven layers up.

GURUMURTHI That's an upside for Corporate India and technically it would get more nimble-footed. We celebrate the success of startups so much that we don't realise that a majority of them fail. It could create a majority of youngsters who fail.

AGARWAL I think I would hire them any day. We take pride in failure. The culture companies build will matter a lot to diffuse the differentiation between startups and established companies. At Amazon it's always based on — 'Think about the customer'. Competitors will go away, market trends will change but a customer's needs are what you're chasing which will never be satisfied. There is a complete safety net. The pride we take in a failure is a lot like startups. Going back and creating a culture like a gang and having a long-term outlook. Established companies may have Wall Street or Dalal Street pressure which they don't get distracted by. If companies can manage the external pressure of an established company but build the pressure of willingness to create and manage it, it's celebrated.

GURUMURTHI What would be your advice to all the young graduates?

MENON One key piece of advice to students on the startups boom — we celebrate successes and we don't talk about failures but as long as there is learning from failures, I would say, the more startups the better. It creates an entrepreneurial culture. We would hire them in a heartbeat. Failures give very different learnings that an established firm doesn't have. My advice is: stay curious and stay learning. As long as there is agility and adaptability, there's going to be success.

Bonding over a selfie



Ajay Srinivasan shares a word of wisdom



Pranab Barua and Sanjay Rishi watch over



Sanjiv Misra speaks to young leaders

